

Title

Pathophysiology-Guided Therapy and Patient Perceptions of Illness in Angina Without Coronary Obstruction: Twelve-Month Findings

Abstract

Many patients with anginal symptoms and angiographically-unobstructed coronaries experience persistent illness-related distress. We randomized 250 participants (mean age 63 years, 50% women) to receive either targeted management guided by cardiac stress imaging (n=124) or conventional angiography-based care (n=126). Illness perception was assessed using standardized instruments at baseline and at 6 and 12-month intervals. At 6 months, participants receiving imaging-directed care reported substantially lower illness perception scores (adjusted mean difference -8.8 points, 95% CI -12.3 to -5.4, $p<0.001$) compared with controls. This improvement was maintained at 12 months (adjusted mean difference -11.0 points, 95% CI -14.6 to -7.4, $p<0.001$). Psychological distress symptoms also showed greater reductions in the imaging-guided group at both 6 months (adjusted mean difference -0.9 points, $p<0.001$) and 12 months (adjusted mean difference -1.0 points, $p<0.001$). The magnitude and persistence of benefit over 12 months highlight the importance of diagnostic clarity in reducing psychological burden.